

surveillance radar, patrol boats, Dorniers

SRI LANKA

Purchases: Patrol boats, radar systems

MYANMAR

Purchases: Naval platforms, artillery, radar systems

UAE

Purchases: Ammunition, protective equipment

OMAN

Purchases: Patrol vessels and naval support equipment

MOZAMBIQUE & OTHER AFRICAN COUNTRIES

Purchases: Fast interceptor boats, armoured vehicles

combat training ecosystem, along with AI-enabled war-gaming solutions. LVC and AI-enabled simulation offer realistic combat experience by recreating battle situations and increases training intensity for militaries. Indian defence exports increasingly comprise such software, simulation, tactical training and electronic systems.

The changing character of warfare has forced militaries to look for cost-effective ways to track and destroy autonomous threats like drones, loitering munitions and precision strikes through air defence platforms and counter-drone systems as well as scout for long-range offensive platforms. All of which create a market for Indian firms.

THE GROWING CUSTOMER BASE FOR INDIA'S PRODUCTS REDUCES DEPENDENCE ON ONE REGION AND HELPS FIRMS UNDERSTAND VARIED PURCHASE SYSTEMS

Noida-based IG Defence, for instance, is developing KAL, a one-way attack drone with a range of 1,000 km and endurance of 7-8 hours with a 50-kg payload. It is positioning KAL as an affordable option of the Shahed class drone. Bodhisattwa Sanghapriya, CEO of IG Defence, says India is uniquely positioned to emerge as a trusted partner for affordable and mission-ready unmanned platforms.

EXPANDING CUSTOMER BASE

India's customer base is also becoming more diverse. Defence exports to Myanmar, the Philippines, Armenia, Sri Lanka, Indonesia, Egypt and other African nations have increasingly involved higher-value platforms, besides exports of military components to the US, Germany and Belgium. The geographical spread reduces dependence on a single region and enables firms to understand varied procurement systems.

Vivek Krishnan of Bengaluru-based SSS Defence, which focuses on weapons like shoulder-fired missiles, small arms and rifles, ammunition and counter-drone systems, says the firm has been exporting since 2022 to nations that include Armenia, Nepal and Sri Lanka. It is exploring opportunities in Southeast Asia, Europe and Africa.

For some manufacturers, however, the supply chain is a constraint. Dependence on overseas components and logistics bottlenecks can all affect operations. "In our case, particularly with weapons, we have maintained control over design, developed our own manufacturing capabilities and built a supporting supplier ecosystem," Krishnan says.

He also believes that India cannot win over competition from established American, European and Israeli manufacturers—as well as from Chinese and Turkish firms—by being the cheapest supplier. "Competitiveness cannot be built on price alone," he says. "Our goal is to establish ourselves as a manufacturer of high-quality products comparable to American, Russian and European brands, while remaining more affordable than Chinese and Turkish ones."

The government's diplomatic push is helping private firms like SSS Defence to get into rooms that would otherwise be difficult to enter. "The government's push for defence exports has helped build confidence among international customers," Krishnan says. "Without this, establishing trust at the highest decision-making levels would be more difficult."

Though India's defence export numbers sit on top of a much larger domestic manufacturing base today, it needs more companies capable of designing and manufacturing complete systems and then delivering and supporting them over decades. The next stage of India's defence-export journey will therefore be about building depth. The success of BrahMos, the emergence of indigenous drones, counter-drone systems and loitering weapons and the rise of private companies in high-technology segments all point towards that direction. The real challenge is for India to turn first-time buyers into repeat customers, contracts into long-term programmes and products into trusted global brands. ■